

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Johnson shifts focus to hirings by Trump

Calls on DOJ for probe into choices made by president

By Daniel C. Vock
Chicago Tribune

WASHINGTON — Facing a federal probe into alleged hiring preferences for Black job candidates, Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson attempted to deftly highlight that it was the president’s hiring practices that were the problem, not his. “My administration reflects the country, the city,” Johnson said as he called on the Department of Justice to turn its sights essentially on itself and investigate President Donald Trump’s hiring. “His administration reflects the country club.”

While Johnson’s gambit to get the DOJ to investigate Trump’s hiring has no chance of succeeding, the first-term mayor’s comments underscore how the president’s picks for top leadership positions have skewed more heavily toward men and white people than any president in recent memory.

Trump’s assault on diversity initiatives has also led to major changes within the agencies charged with fighting discrimination. His administration has dismantled many traditional approaches for combating racial and gender bias, while using headline-grabbing

Turn to Hiring, Page 2

Hate crime charged in Colorado attack

Authorities: Suspect plotted over year to target Jewish group

By Colleen Slevin and Eric Tucker
Associated Press

BOULDER, Colo. — A man accused of throwing Molotov cocktails into a Colorado group that had gathered to bring attention to Israeli hostages in Gaza planned the attack for more than a year and specifically targeted what he described as a “Zionist group,” authorities said in court papers unsealed Monday charging him with a federal hate crime.

Witnesses in Boulder said the suspect, Mohammed Sabry Soliman, 45, yelled “Free Palestine” and used incendiary devices. Twelve people were injured in the attack, some with burns, as a group was concluding their weekly demonstration.

An FBI affidavit says Soliman confessed to the attack after being taken into custody Sunday and told the police he would do

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New pickleball courts and baseball and soccer fields are visible along South Wells Street in The 78, a long vacant 62-acre former rail yard site in the South Loop. The Chicago Fire have plans to build a 22,000-seat stadium on the north end of the development. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Chicago Fire plan \$650M soccer facility at The 78

■ Privately financed stadium to be development anchor in South Loop

■ Target completion date to be ahead of the 2028 MLS regular season

By Robert Channick
Chicago Tribune

After nearly a decade of big swings and misses, including a recent failed bid to build a new White Sox ballpark, The 78 and developer Related Midwest may have finally found an anchor tenant to kick-start the proposed mixed-use megadevelopment in the South Loop.

The Chicago Fire announced plans Tuesday for a privately financed \$650 million soccer stadium at the mostly vacant 62-acre site along the Chicago River at Roosevelt Road, giving the team a “world-class home,” and potentially turning the

former rail yard into a bustling South Side Wrigleyville.

“It’s transformative for the club, and I think for the city as well,” said Fire owner Joe Mansueto, 68, the founder and executive chairman of Chicago-based investment research firm Morningstar, who bought the team in 2019.

Designed by architectural firm Gensler, the proposed 22,000-seat, open-air soccer stadium would be located at the north end of the long-fallow development. It would feature a natural grass pitch, an array of seating — including club options and luxury suites — and an intimate setting for fans to cheer the Fire on match days.

The new stadium is scheduled to break ground as early as this fall, pending approval from the city, with a target completion date ahead of the 2028 MLS regular season. The Fire currently play at a rarely filled Soldier Field on a newly signed three-year lease extension.

Mansueto said the new right-sized soccer stadium will be the perfect fit for Fire fans and the city.

“I think we should sell out every game,” Mansueto said. “We want to create this unrivaled match day experience.”

The undeveloped swath of land bordered by Roosevelt Road, Clark Street and a half-

mile stretch of riverfront south of downtown Chicago, has been a field of dreams for Related Midwest since acquiring it in 2016. The ambitious plan from the outset was to create a sprawling residential, retail and commercial development that would become the city’s 78th neighborhood.

Over the years, The 78 has been in the running for everything from Amazon’s second headquarters to a Chicago casino, but time and again, Related was unable to land that elusive anchor tenant to catalyze the megadevelopment. Last year, the White Sox proposed a new publicly funded ballpark

Turn to Stadium, Page 4

Puerto Rican rapper champions endangered toad



Mike Masellis, Brookfield Zoo’s lead animal care specialist for aquatics, holds a Puerto Rican crested toad May 13 at the zoo. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Bad Bunny gives boost to Brookfield Zoo’s conservation efforts

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

A chatty animated amphibian starring in videos for Bad Bunny’s recent album has launched the Puerto Rican crested toad — an endangered species native to the island — into newfound fame, following years of quiet, collaborative conservation efforts involving Chicago’s Brookfield Zoo.

“They’re kind of famous now,” said Mike Masellis, Brookfield Zoo’s lead animal care specialist for aquatics. While getting his oil

changed at an auto shop recently, he noticed a kid in the waiting room was wearing a hoodie with an image of the toad. “It’s exciting to see people become aware of the species.”

The Puerto Rican reggaeton and rap artist directed a short film in which the crested toad — *sapo concho* in Spanish — lends an ear to an old man reminiscing about his life on the island and wishing he’d taken more photos. In a stop-motion music video, *sapo concho* goes clubbing as he pines over what seems to be unrequited love for a female toad; in Spotify the songs play alongside videos of the toad enjoying a cup of coffee, tending

Turn to Toads, Page 4

Probe: No violations at nonprofit

A state probe at Cook County’s hospital nonprofit has closed with no violations found. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Ill. session ends without funding

For months, transit agencies have sounded an alarm over a looming \$771 million budget gap. **Business**

No progress toward ending war

Representatives of Russia and Ukraine met Monday for a round of direct peace talks. **Nation & World**

TODAY’S WEATHER



High 88 Low 62

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